limited. India did receive some official development assistance (ODA) from Japan, while South Korean companies successfully entered the Indian market. Southeast Asia also saw more of a strategic vacuum after the end of the Cold War: Russia had closed bases at Da Nang and Cam Ranh Bay in Vietnam and the United States departed from the Philippines. In this context, the desire of Southeast Asian economies to engage with India increased. ‘Looking East’ was also a less contentious way in India of introducing market forces and cooperating with US allies and partners, which meant that it also helped India ‘Look West’. In 1992, India established official contacts with the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), an institution that had once been associated with anti-communism and viewed by New Delhi with a great deal of scepticism. [8] The military aspect of this engagement also slowly took off. In 1995, the Indian Navy began the Milan multilateral exercises, initially involving Indonesia, Singapore, and Thailand.

The other significant diplomatic breakthrough immediately after 1991 was with Israel. India had recognized Israel in September 1950; at the time, the two countries were already working together at the United Nations and India was following a precedent set six months earlier by Iran. Although Israel had a consul in Bombay from 1953, India opted not to establish diplomatic ties because it felt it was necessary to compete with Pakistan for support from Muslim-majority countries on issues such as Jammu and Kashmir. A series of crises in both West and South Asia in the late 1960s and early 1970s opened prospects for a diversification of India’s West Asia policy, but New Delhi was also constrained by a greater dependence on oil imports from the Gulf states. That did not stop Indira Gandhi from accepting military assistance from Israel in the run up to the 1971 Bangladesh War. However, in 1975, India recognized and initiated diplomatic ties with the Palestinian Liberation Organization (PLO) and after the Israeli attack on Iraq’s Osirak nuclear reactor, India expelled Israel’s consul in Bombay in 1982, marking a low point in relations. [9]

By the late 1980s, it became clear that the absence of India–Israel diplomatic ties was hindering other efforts, including Rajiv Gandhi’s